‘India’s century’ and insisted that strategic autonomy and independent decision making were the hallmark of Indian foreign policy.[10]

Using poetic language, President K.R. Narayanan described India’s foreign policy as ‘alchemy’ of ‘the thirst for Independence, the desire to safeguard our national interest, the desire to pursue peace and cooperation in our environment and in the world as a whole’.[11] In reality, however, India’s approach was one of maintaining the status quo while, in the words of a retired Indian official, ‘preaching to others what we don’t practise ourselves’. [12] Over the years, critics point out, India has generally only reacted to whatever the rest of the world does instead of taking many initiatives. Indian leaders and diplomats take pride in India being ‘one of the few countries that is able to talk on reasonably friendly terms with everybody in the world’, [13] a reflection of policies designed to muddle through instead of charting a new course.

PRIME MINISTERIAL PRE-EMINENCE

After Independence, India chose not to discard or disrupt the structure of state created during British colonial rule. Instead, the existing institutions of government were only slightly modified and adapted to work for a sovereign nation instead of serving a colonial regime. India’s decision making on foreign policy too rests on the set of institutions most of which can be traced back to the Raj.

Within two years of the departure of the British from the subcontinent, India adopted a constitution in 1949 modelled on the Westminster form of parliamentary democracy. The first general elections on the basis of universal adult franchise were held in 1951–52. As in most democracies, members of parliament reflected their constituents and were more concerned with local issues than global ones. As prime minister, Nehru was the country’s chief executive and, in effect, provided continuity from an era that vested all authority in the office of the viceroy. Thus, the office of